INCIDENT RESPONSE PLAYBOOK

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Author: Fatema T. Johra

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1. Purpose

This Incident Response (IR) Playbook defines the standardized process for identifying, containing, eradicating, and recovering from cybersecurity incidents. The objective is to minimize business impact, preserve forensic integrity, and restore operations efficiently while maintaining regulatory and governance compliance.

2. Scope

This playbook applies to:

- Enterprise infrastructure (on-premises and cloud)
- Endpoints and servers
- Identity and access management systems
- SaaS platforms (Microsoft 365, etc.)
- Network security devices
- Third-party integrated systems

3. Incident Severity Classification

Severity	Description	Example
Critical	Active compromise impacting business operations	Ransomware, domain admin compromise
High	Confirmed malicious activity with limited spread	Privileged account abuse
Medium	Suspicious activity requiring investigation	Malware detection
Low	Policy violation or low-risk alert	Phishing attempt blocked

4. Incident Response Lifecycle

This framework aligns with the NIST Incident Response Lifecycle.

4.1 Preparation

- Maintain updated IR policies and SOPs
- Ensure logging enabled across systems
- Validate SIEM and alerting configurations
- Conduct tabletop exercises quarterly
- Maintain contact lists and escalation paths

Deliverables:

- Updated IR documentation
- Validated runbooks
- Testing reports

4.2 Identification

Objectives:

- Confirm whether an event is a true security incident
- Determine scope and impact

Actions:

- Review SIEM alerts
- Correlate logs (endpoint, network, cloud)
- Identify indicators of compromise (IOCs)
- Assess privilege escalation or lateral movement
- Determine initial attack vector

Deliverables:

- Incident ticket
- Preliminary impact assessment
- Severity classification

4.3 Containment

Short-Term Containment:

- Isolate affected endpoints
- Disable compromised accounts

- Block malicious IPs/domains
- Apply firewall restrictions

Long-Term Containment:

- Apply patches
- Harden configurations
- Reset credentials
- Implement additional monitoring

Deliverables:

- Containment report
- Evidence preservation documentation

4.4 Eradication

Objectives:

- Remove malicious artifacts
- Eliminate persistence mechanisms

Actions:

- Remove malware
- Clean registry modifications
- Validate system integrity
- Reimage systems if required
- Confirm no residual backdoors

Deliverables:

- Forensic validation summary
- Root cause analysis report

4.5 Recovery

Objectives:

- Restore systems to operational state
- Monitor for recurrence

Actions:

- Restore from clean backups
- Validate application functionality
- Re-enable accounts
- Increase logging and monitoring
- Conduct enhanced monitoring for 14–30 days

Deliverables:

- Recovery validation report
- Business impact summary

4.6 Lessons Learned

Conduct post-incident review within 5–10 business days.

Agenda:

- Timeline reconstruction
- Root cause analysis
- Response effectiveness review
- Communication evaluation
- Control gaps identified

Outputs:

- After Action Report (AAR)
- Updated SOPs
- Security control improvement plan

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5. Communication Plan

Internal Communication:

- SOC Team
- IT Infrastructure
- Security Leadership
- Legal/Compliance (if required)

Executive Communication:

- Risk-based summary

- Business impact analysis
- Recommended remediation roadmap

External Communication (if applicable):

- Regulatory bodies
- Customers
- Third-party vendors

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6. Evidence Handling and Chain of Custody

- Document evidence collection time/date
- Preserve original artifacts
- Use write-blockers for forensic imaging
- Store evidence securely
- Maintain integrity hashes

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7. Documentation Requirements

For each incident:

- Incident ticket number
- Timeline of events
- Indicators of compromise
- Affected systems
- Containment steps taken
- Eradication methods
- Recovery validation
- Lessons learned

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8. Metrics and Continuous Improvement

9. Tools and Technologies

Examples:

- SIEM: Splunk
- SOAR: Automated response workflows
- Endpoint Detection and Response (EDR)
- Cloud Logging (AWS CloudTrail, Azure Monitor)
- Forensic Tools (FTK, EnCase)

End of Playbook